Bridging the Effort Gap In Your Relationship

Created By: Baya Voce
MSW, Columbia University

A Letter from Baya

Hey you,

If you're here, there's a good chance you've felt alone in the effort. You're doing the inner work, starting the conversations, noticing the patterns, and trying to shift them. Still, it feels like you're carrying the emotional weight of the relationship on your own.

This workbook is for the moments when you feel in it alone. Maybe your partner deeply cares, but something still feels off. You might be caught in a dynamic Dr. Alexandra Solomon refers to as the effort mismatch.

One of you leans toward change… growth, processing, hard truths. The other leans toward acceptance… peace, presence, keeping things easy.

Neither is better (although, depending on your position, you're likely eye-rolling at the other, feeling like they're the problem). However, if you don't name the mismatch, it becomes a wedge. This guide is about naming it, understanding it, and gently navigating it, without turning your partner into a project or turning yourself into a martyr.

Inside, you'll find language, reflections, and practices to help you:

- Understand your role (and your partner's)
- Stop making each other wrong for how you love
- Begin meeting in the middle

True connection doesn't come from perfect communication, it comes from staying in it, especially when things feel uneven.

Let's begin.

Baya

Before You Start

What is an Effort Mismatch?

Most people think that if one partner is doing more emotional work, the relationship must be broken or completely lopsided, but that's not always true.

Sometimes, the relationship is fine… but the dynamic between you needs language.

Enter: The Effort Mismatch.

In many relationships, one partner takes on the role of the **Change Partner**, the one who seeks growth, wants to name patterns, and leans toward transformation.

The other partner takes on the role of the **Acceptance Partner**, the one who values peace, presence, and loving things as they are.

These roles often emerge unconsciously. They're shaped by past relationships, family dynamics, nervous system wiring, and our natural emotional set point.

The problem isn't the roles; it's when you don't talk about them. That's when resentment builds. One partner feels like they're dragging the relationship forward, the other feels like no matter what they do, it's never doing enough, or that they're always under pressure.

This dynamic, when it goes unnamed, creates a polarization that grows over time. This workbook gives that dynamic a name, a shape, and a path forward because once you understand it, you can move through it, together.

Meet the Change Partner & the Acceptance Partner

In many relationships, there is one partner who carries the charge for transformation and growth. This is the Change Partner.

The **Change Partner** is the one who initiates conversations about feelings, sends the podcast episode, books the couples workshop, and often feels responsible for the emotional tone of the relationship. They tend to believe that closeness is created by doing the work, and when they don't feel connected, their first instinct is to fix or explore why.

The **Acceptance Partner** plays a different but equally important role. They are more focused on being present, staying grounded, and returning to ease. They tend to believe that closeness is created through shared time and relaxed energy, not heavy processing conversations. When they don't feel connected, their instinct may be to let things cool off and return to normal.

Both roles offer gifts, and both come with blind spots.

For instance, the Change Partner may unintentionally make their partner feel like a project and they can become overly focused on what's missing, which makes it difficult to see what's working.

The Acceptance Partner might avoid discomfort or minimize concerns in the name of keeping the peace. Their resistance to "digging in" can leave the other partner feeling alone in the growth.

Neither partner is wrong, but if this difference goes unspoken, the relationship can get stuck in a loop: one partner pushing for more, the other pulling away.

The goal isn't to change each other, it's to understand the roles you've both been playing, and create more space for curiosity, respect, and shared responsibility.

THE IMPACT OF THE MISMATCH

When one partner leans into change and the other leans into acceptance, it's easy for misunderstanding to take root. Without naming what's happening, both partners can end up feeling alone in the relationship, even while sitting right next to each other. Here's what this effort mismatch often creates:

For the Change Partner:

- A growing sense of resentment: *"Why am I the only one trying?"*
- The belief that they must carry the emotional labor: *"If I don't initiate the conversation, we'll never talk about it."*
- A tendency to over-function, often at the cost of their own regulation or clarity.

For the Acceptance Partner:

- A feeling of inadequacy: *"I can never do enough or say it right."*
- A fear of always being under scrutiny: *"There's always something wrong with me or with us."*
- A desire to retreat or shut down, especially when they feel overwhelmed.

Over time, the relationship can begin to feel lopsided. One partner is exhausted from trying to pull the other along, and the other is overwhelmed from feeling like they're constantly behind. This dynamic isn't necessarily a sign that you're not right for each other. In fact, we often do attract our opposites. This is a signal, though, that your emotional efforts are being expressed differently, and that those differences need care, language, and mutual recognition.

Once this pattern is named, it no longer has to run the show. Awareness creates the space to respond instead of react, and to come back to each other with compassion instead of frustration.

What this is not

Before we go any further, let's clear something up:

This dynamic isn't about who's doing it "right."

When you're the one reading the books, initiating the conversations, or seeking support, it's easy to believe you're the one "doing the work." But emotional effort looks different for everyone, and just because your partner isn't doing it your way doesn't mean they're not trying.

This is not:

- A diagnostic tool
- A blame game
- A hierarchy of growth
- A reason to prove you're more evolved

This is:

- A lens to bring compassion to the space between you
- A way to language the invisible effort you've both been making
- A tool to help you reconnect from mutual understanding, not righteousness

Here's the truth:

The Change Partner isn't always right (as the Change Partner myself, this was a hard pill to swallow for me), and the Acceptance Partner isn't always avoidant. Growth doesn't always look like a breakthrough moment. Sometimes, love sounds like silence, stillness, or space.

This workbook is here to help you decode your unique rhythm as a couple, not to override it with someone else's idea of what growth should look like.

Here's What the...
Change Partner Needs to Hear

If you're the one reading this, chances are you're the Change Partner.

You're the one who brings things up, seeks growth, notices patterns, and who keeps saying, "We can be better than this."

Your emotional labor is real, and it's valid to feel tired. But sometimes, without meaning to, your growth orientation becomes a silent message to your partner: "Who you are now and what you are doing now isn't enough."

You might not say it that way, but the constant reaching, analyzing, and fixing can leave them feeling like they're always failing.

Here's the thing… not everyone processes in real time or out loud. Just because they're not moving at your pace doesn't mean they're not moving. Dr. Stan Tatkin talks about the tortoise and the hare. The tortoise processes very slowly; the hare at warp speed.

Your partner may not speak your language of growth, but they likely have their own, and if you slow down long enough to learn it, you might see that there's more happening than you thought.

Growth isn't just in the reaching. Sometimes, it's in the resting. In being able to sit with what is. This is different than apathy or giving up; it's developing the stamina to build trust that the relationship isn't solely yours to carry.

You don't have to do all the work or be the translator, the therapist, and the architect of every repair.

You get to ask for support, be held, and stop mid-conflict and say, "I don't want to figure this out alone."

You are not the only one trying, but if you keep acting like you are, your partner might start believing it too. If they know someone else is going to pick up the load or that no matter what they do, it's not going to be enough, anyway, it's hard to be inspired towards growth.

Here's What the...

Acceptance Partner Needs to Hear

If you're reading this and feeling a little called out, this page is for you.
You're the one who values presence and doesn't want every moment to become a lesson.

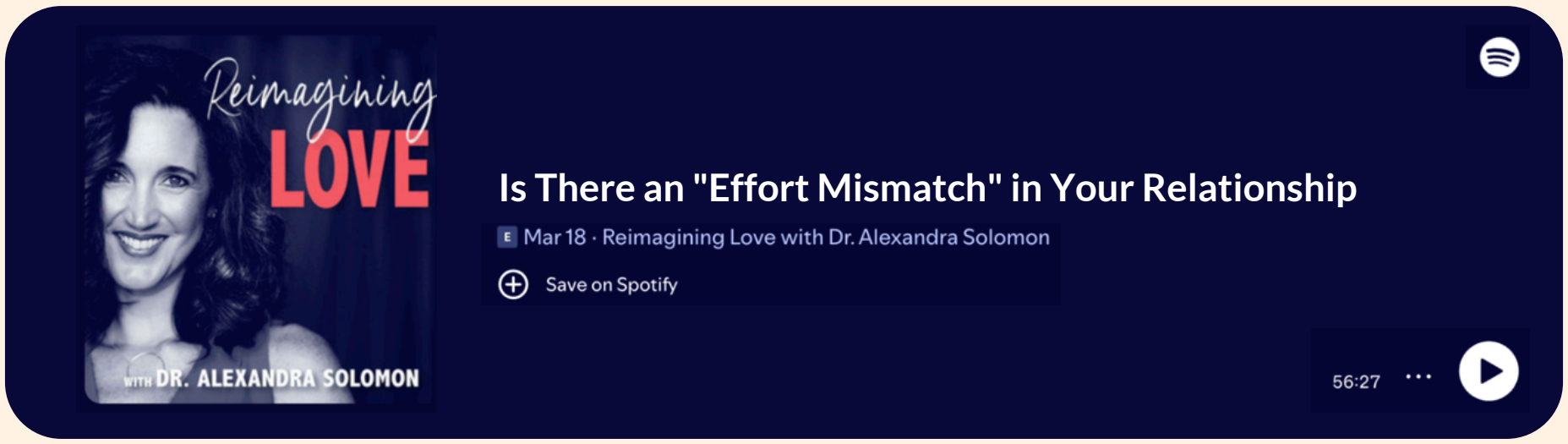
The one who believes love should feel peaceful, not like a never-ending project.
That's not wrong, your way of loving is beautiful (albeit foreign to a Change Partner).

Sometimes, in your desire for calm, you avoid the conversation, go quiet, minimize, shut down, or say "it's fine", even when it's not. The hope is that if you just give it time, it'll go away.

You're not lazy or broken, as much as your Change Partner might say (or think) otherwise. (Calling myself out for this one, I have certainly felt this about my wife).
You're someone who's learned to survive by keeping things smooth because that's what feels like safety.

Check out Dr. Solomon's Podcast

If you're the Acceptance Partner, I encourage you to listen to this podcast episode as Dr. Solomon will shift your perspective on how to maximize the benefits of the Effort Mismatch.



Shared Reflection Questions

This section is designed for both partners to explore, together or separately. You can journal, take turns asking each other, or simply read through and pause where it hits.

There are no right answers here... just honest ones.

1. When you think about our relationship, who usually brings things up first? How do you feel about that?

2. Do you see yourself more as the Change Partner or the Acceptance Partner? Or do those roles shift depending on the situation?

3. What's something your partner does emotionally that you might've misunderstood or underappreciated?

4. What's something you've been longing to hear, but haven't known how to ask for?

5. In what ways do you show love differently? Where do you miss each other, even though you're both trying?

6. When do you feel most connected as a couple? What are the conditions that make that possible?

7. What's one small shift you're each willing to try, to meet in the middle more often?

It's important you're both doing the work here to not blame or fix your "broken partner." You're making the invisible visible so you can see how the dynamics play out in your relationship. Understanding your partner is the first step toward honoring each other's differences and creating repair that works for both of you.

Journal Section for Change Partner

Below you'll find space to journal about the reflection questions:

Journal Section for Acceptance Partner

Below you'll find space to journal about the reflection questions:

A PRACTICE TO TRY

The Effort Mirror

This practice helps you both see what effort looks like from the other's perspective. It creates space for appreciation, softens resentment, and reveals how you're each showing up, sometimes in ways that go unnoticed.

Step 1: Set the Scene

Choose a time when neither of you is distracted, exhausted, or in conflict. Sit facing each other. No phones or multitasking, just 10–15 minutes of presence.

Step 2: Take Turns Sharing

Each person answers the following prompt out loud, while the other simply listens:

"One thing I've done recently to care for this relationship is…"

You can share something big or small. Maybe it's "I read something about communication because I want to get better at it," or "I didn't bring up something that bothered me because I knew your plate was full." The only goal is the reveal.

Step 3: Reflect Back

After each share, the listener reflects back what they heard, beginning with:

"What I hear you saying is…"

Then, simply say thank you. No fixing. No "but." Just acknowledgment.

Continue to the next page...

Step 4: Switch

Repeat the steps above for the other partner.

Optional Extension:

After both have shared, close with this question:

"What's one thing I can do this week that would help you feel more supported?"

Again, simple is powerful. Maybe it's a small check-in, a moment of affection, or space to be quiet. This practice is much less about perfect technique and way more about mutual effort. It helps balance the emotional labor, reveal unseen contributions, and move you from a polarizing dynamic back into partnership.

Words to Say

(When You Don't Know What to Say)

Sometimes the hardest part of repair is starting. These aren't magic words, but they are honest ones. Use them when you're stuck, overwhelmed, or just don't know where to begin.

Choose one. Or let them inspire your own.

If you're the Change Partner:

- "I know I bring a lot of emotions to the table. I just want us to be close."
- "I'm trying to grow without making you feel like you're not enough."
- "Sometimes I lead with fixing when what I really want is connection."
- "I don't want to be the only one initiating this, but I care enough to try."

Continue to the next page...

If you're the Acceptance Partner:

- “I know I don’t always have the words, but I’m listening.”
- “I’m working on being more open, even if it feels unfamiliar.”
- “Just because I don’t say much doesn’t mean I don’t care.”
- “I want to be here with you, even if I move slower.”

For either partner:

- “I think we’re on the same team, I just forgot for a second.”
- “Let’s pause. I want to do this in a way that doesn’t hurt us more.”
- “This is hard… and I still want us.”
- “Can we try again, but slower this time?”

When language feels too big, start small. These phrases aren’t scripts to memorize. They’re invitations, back to each other.

Why this practice is important:

Because effort is easy to overlook, especially the kind that’s quiet. You’re doing things your partner doesn’t see. They’re doing things you don’t notice. And somewhere in the middle, the story becomes: “I’m alone in this.”

The Effort Mirror gives that story a pause. It invites you to see clearly, speak kindly, and listen without fixing. It’s not about tallying effort, it’s about witnessing it. And being witnessed.

This is where resentment softens. Where connection starts to return. Not in the big moments, but in the ordinary ones, the ones where someone says, “I see you.”

What if You Feel Unequally Invested?

This is one of the deepest aches in relationships:

“I feel like I care more than they do.”

It’s vulnerable, frustrating, and it’s not always true.

Sometimes, it’s not about unequal love but about different expressions of love.

One partner may show care through talking it out. The other through being steady.

One wants to understand everything. The other wants to keep peace.

This creates a loop:

- One partner feels like they’re carrying the emotional load.
- The other feels like nothing they do is enough.
- Resentment builds on both sides.

Here’s the thing… there may be an imbalance, or there may be a mismatch in how effort looks and feels.

Either way, the antidote isn’t accusation, it’s conversation.

Try saying:

- “I want to feel like we’re both tending to this.”
- “Can we talk about what emotional effort looks like for each of us?”
- “I’m noticing a pattern, and I’d rather name it than let it keep growing.”

The goal isn’t to prove who’s doing more, but to name the dynamic so it doesn’t run the relationship from the shadows.

The Practice of Naming

Sometimes the most powerful shift comes from the smallest action: **naming what's happening** in the moment it's happening so you can **witness** it together.

You might say:

"I think we're in our mismatch again."
"This feels like that loop we fall into."
"I'm the Change Partner here, huh?"
"This is our freeze moment, isn't it?"

Naming a pattern disrupts the trance of disconnection and invites presence. It offers a pause and reminds you both that you're on the same team, even if you're wired differently.

Why this works:

- It creates shared language for moments that used to feel isolating.
- It shifts the dynamic from me vs. you to us vs. the pattern.
- It builds trust because it says: I see it, I'm not running from it, and I want to meet you here.

You don't have to name it perfectly. Just name it and hopefully you'll be able to see a softening on both ends.

Practice tip:

Before you name the pattern, drop into your body. Ask yourself:

> "Am I naming this to connect or to be right?

If it's connection, soften your voice. Stay with the moment. Let the naming be an invitation, not a jab.

CLOSING NOTE

If this workbook landed in your hands, it's because some part of you wants more, more connection, more clarity, more safety in your relationships.

To me, that's sacred work.

Most people don't pause to name the pattern or stop and reflect. Why? Because it really takes something to try over and over again with more care.

But you are.

So whether you're the Change Partner or the Acceptance Partner, or figuring it out as you go, thank you for being someone who stays in the conversation.

Repair isn't always clean or easy, but I promise you it is always worth it.

When we name what's real, when we stay open through the tension, when we soften toward each other…

We don't just fix what's broken, **we build something better (and often something no one in our families growing up modeled for us). This means by doing this work you create something new that has the potential to go beyond just you and your partner, but to change painful generational patterns so they end with you.**

In it with you,

Baya Voce